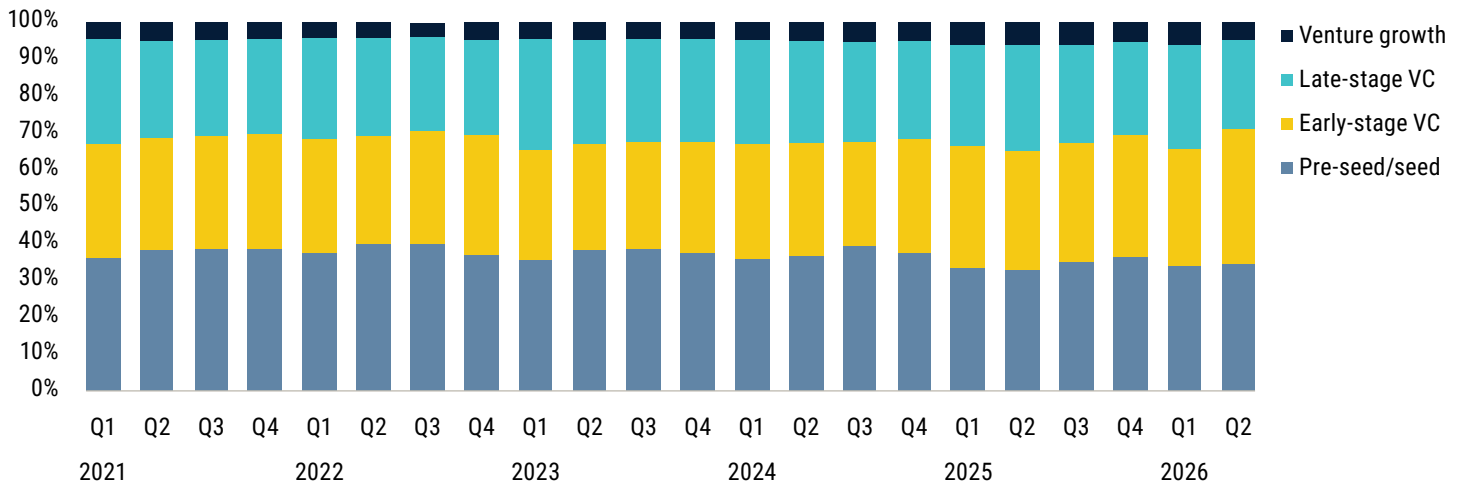


The share of late-stage and venture-growth deals dips QoQ

Quarterly share of VC deal count by stage



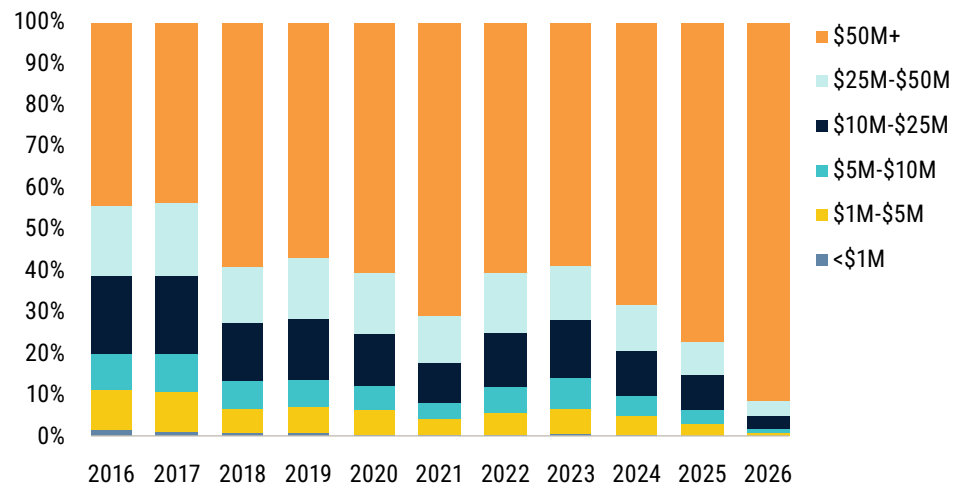
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necessarily signal the end of outsized financings of tens of billions of dollars. The next few quarters should surface the latest batch of companies able to command that kind of capital: names familiar to investors even if they do not yet carry the broad public recognition of Anthropic or OpenAI.

AI maintained its dominance in the tech sector, an extension of a yearslong trend. The shift is structural. AI has lowered the cost to build tech, with AI coding tools speeding up product development and foundation models giving founders a base layer to develop upon without having to train their own models. The talent that can build at the frontier, though, is scarce and clustered on the West Coast, particularly the Bay Area, so if capital keeps following that talent, value creation in AI may stay geographically concentrated. First-time financings reached an estimated 5,674 deals in H1 2026, putting the year on pace to see more than 10,000 companies raising their first venture round, which would be a record.

Deals over \$50 million make up an unprecedentedly high share of total deal value

Share of VC deal value by size bucket



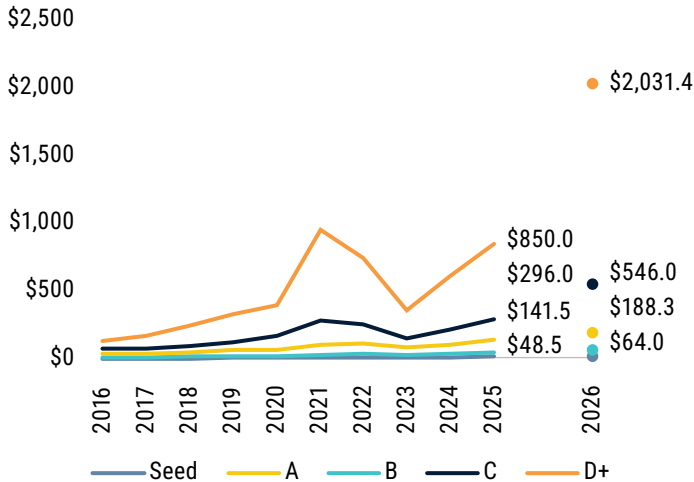
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Valuations have not just recovered from the 2022-to-2023 correction; they have pushed past their 2021 highs at every series. The median pre-money valuation more than doubled relative to 2021 at pre-seed, seed, and Series D+. Among the middle stages, Series C came closest at 95%, followed by

Series A at 89.9% and Series B at 83.3%. The driver differs from that of the 2021 surge. Then, low rates and abundant liquidity lifted valuations broadly. Now, AI is the main force as expectations of fast revenue growth and market capture push the largest valuations higher and set comparables across stages. That

Median Series D+ pre-money valuation already more than double 2025 level

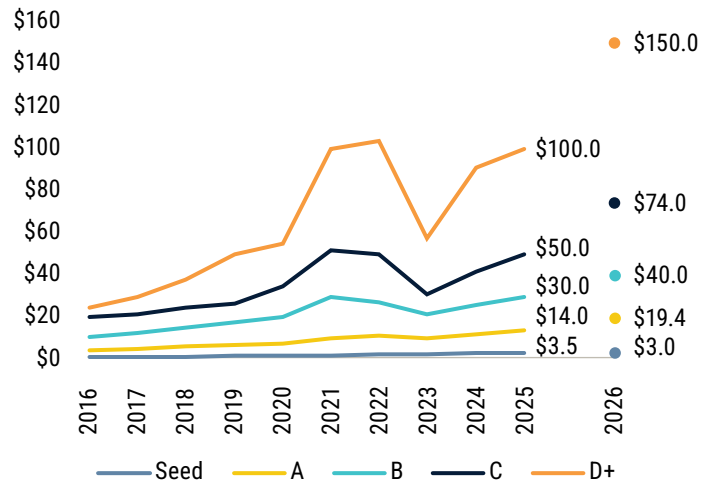
Median VC pre-money valuation (\$M) by series



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Median deal value continues to ascend across all series except for seed

Median VC deal value (\$M) by series



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reliance on a single theme raises the risk of a broad correction if AI growth or returns fall short. The power law of venture compounds the risk: Even if AI delivers, returns will concentrate in a small number of winners, so funding a wide field at elevated prices leaves many of those entries exposed.

Many of the largest rounds are structured in tranches, or they fold in prior commitments. For instance, \$15 billion of Anthropic's \$65 billion round was committed earlier, so the figure cited in media headlines overstated the new money going into the company. The post-money valuation, usually the highest mark in the round, is not the price every investor pays. That figure

can be misleading: It reflects the top valuation in the round, not a common entry price, and it can overstate the momentum behind a company. In a market this competitive, those marks can intensify the scramble to get onto the cap tables of the most sought-after AI companies.

The gap between private and public valuations remains an obstacle. Even with public indexes near record highs, listings have been limited, and several recent ones priced below their last private rounds. Investors across stages have questioned whether every company carrying a high valuation can reach the \$1 billion+ outcome it implies. High entry prices raise the bar for the

growth and exits needed to justify them, and some of these companies will not clear it.

The next six months will test these bets. Companies that raised at elevated prices on compressed timelines need to show fast growth to justify their valuations and raise again, or they risk a down round. The mega-IPO of SpaceX and the pending ones from OpenAI and Anthropic will reveal whether public investors will validate private marks. The time between rounds has compressed, especially for AI companies, so the margin for error is thin, and investors and their LPs will be watching for growth that meets elevated expectations.